Han, Zhixian

Purdue University | han594@purdue.edu | +1 (612)961-2676

Professional Experience

2026 – Present Postdoctoral Researcher, Purdue University

2025 – 2026 Limited-Term Lecturer and Postdoctoral Researcher, Purdue University

2025 Graduate Lecturer, Purdue University

2024 Consultant, Purdue Statistical Consulting Service (SCS), Purdue University

2021 Lead Teaching Assistant, Neuromatch Academy (Computational Neuroscience Summer Course, International Online Program)

2019 – 2024 Graduate Teaching Assistant, Purdue University

2015 – 2017 Undergraduate Research Assistant, University of Minnesota, Twin Cities

Education

2019 – 2025	Ph.D. in Psychology (Mathematical and Computational Cognitive Science), Purdue University
2021 – 2025	Joint M.S. in Statistics and Computer Science, Purdue University
2019 – 2021	M.S. in Psychology, Purdue University
2017 – 2019	M.S. in Physics, Brown University
2014 – 2017	B.S. in Physics and B.S. in Psychology, University of Minnesota, Twin Cities
2012 – 2014	Undergraduate studies in Physics, Sichuan University (transferred)

Peer-reviewed Journal Articles

Yi-Fan Li, Elizabeth M. Edwards, **Zhixian Han**, and Anne Sereno. "Using neural networks to understand static and dynamic cues in facial expression recognition". In: *Vision Research* 244 (2026), pp. 1–13. DOI: 10.1016/j.visres.2026.108827.

Zhixian Han and Anne B. Sereno. "Exploring Neural Architectures for Simultaneously Recognizing Multiple Visual Attributes". In: *Scientific Reports* 14.30036 (2024c). DOI: 10.1038/s41598-024-80679-6.

Zhixian Han and Anne B. Sereno. "Understanding Cortical Streams From a Computational Perspective". In: *Journal of Cognitive Neuroscience* 36.12 (2024b), pp. 2618–2626. DOI: 10.1162/jocn_a_02121.

Zhixian Han and Anne B. Sereno. "A Spatial Map: A Propitious Choice for Constraining the Binding Problem". In: *Frontiers in Computational Neuroscience* 18 (2024a). DOI: 10.3389/fncom.2024.1397819.

Zhixian Han and Anne Sereno. "Identifying and Localizing Multiple Objects Using Artificial Ventral and Dorsal Cortical Visual Pathways". In: *Neural Computation* 35.2 (2023), pp. 249–275. DOI: 10.1162/neco_a_01559.

Zhixian Han and Anne Sereno. "Modeling the Ventral and Dorsal Cortical Visual Pathways Using Artificial Neural Networks". In: *Neural Computation* 34.1 (2022), pp. 138–171. DOI: 10.1162/neco_a_01456.

Conference Abstracts

Anne Sereno, **Zhixian Han**, and Elizabeth M. Frazier. "A Computational Perspective on Segregated Processing and the Privileged Role of Space in Binding". In: *Computational and Mathematical Models in Vision (MODVIS)*. 2025. URL: https://docs.lib.purdue.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1248&context=modvis.

Zhixian Han, Vlada Volyanskaya, and Anne B. Sereno. "A Biologically Inspired Framework for Contrastive Learning of Visual Representations: BioCLR". In: *Journal of Vision*. 2024. DOI: 10.1167/jov.24.10.771.

Zhixian Han and Anne Sereno. "Is It Always Computationally Advantageous to Use Segregated Pathways to Process Different Visual Stimulus Attributes Separately?" In: *Journal of Vision*. 2023. DOI: 10.1167/jov.23.9.5020.

Anne B. Sereno and **Zhixian Han**. "Independence, Not Interactions: What Simulations Suggest about Ventral and Dorsal Pathways". In: *Journal of Vision*. 2023. DOI: 10.1167/jov.23.9.4606.

Zhixian Han and Anne Sereno. "Constraining the Binding Problem Using Maps". In: *Computational and Mathematical Models in Vision (MODVIS)*. 2023. URL: https://docs.lib.purdue.edu/modvis/2023/session03/2/.

Zhixian Han and Anne Sereno. "Identifying and Localizing Multiple Objects Using Artificial Ventral and Dorsal Visual Cortical Pathways". In: *Computational and Mathematical Models in Vision (MODVIS)*. 2022. URL: https://docs.lib.purdue.edu/modvis/2022/session01/3/.

Working Papers

Zhixian Han, Yifan Li, Vlada Volyanskaya, and Anne B. Sereno. "A Biologically Inspired Contrastive Learning Framework (BioCLR) for Cross-Stream Visual Representation Learning." Manuscript in preparation.

Research Experience

Attentional Modulation of Shape and Location Representations in Human Visual Cortex: An fMRI Study May 2026 – Present

Postdoctoral Researcher, Purdue University; Advisor: Dr. Anne Sereno

- Investigate how shape attention and spatial attention modulate neural representations of object shape and spatial location in the human visual cortex.
- Analyze fMRI data from shape-attention, location-attention, and fixation tasks involving different shapes presented at different spatial locations.
- Implement fMRI preprocessing, single-trial beta estimation, and multivariate pattern decoding pipelines to measure shape and location information across lower- and higher-level visual areas in the ventral and dorsal cortical pathways.
- Compare decoding performance across shape-attention, location-attention, and fixation conditions to determine how attentional demands affect visual representations across different visual areas.

Cross-Stream Contrastive Learning of Visual Representations September 2025 – Present

Postdoctoral Researcher, Purdue University; Advisor: Dr. Anne Sereno

- Develop a contrastive learning framework for cross-stream visual representation learning, enabling interactions between specialized visual streams.
- Implement teacher–student distillation pipelines using deep neural networks.
- Analyze how interactions between specialized streams trained on different visual attributes shape learned

visual representations.

Modeling Emotional Effects on Lexical Decision Performance April 2026 – Present

Postdoctoral Researcher, Purdue University; Advisor: Dr. Anne Sereno

- Investigate how anxiety and serenity inductions affect response times and accuracy for positively and negatively valenced words during lexical decision.
- Analyze trial-level behavioral data using mixed-effects models while accounting for linguistic variables and between-participant variability.
- Develop a hierarchical generative model with participant-specific evidence-accumulation rates, decision boundaries, nondecision times, and attentional-lapse probabilities, with emotional induction allowed to modulate each mechanism.
- Apply simulation-based inference to estimate population- and participant-level parameters and evaluate competing mechanisms using parameter recovery, model recovery, and posterior predictive checks.

Understanding the Visual Cortical Pathways from a Computational Perspective

Graduate Researcher, Purdue University; Advisor: Dr. Anne Sereno September 2019 – August 2025

- Developed artificial neural network models of ventral and dorsal cortical visual pathways to study object recognition, spatial localization, and multi-attribute binding.
- Designed experiments comparing segregated and integrated architectures for processing and binding visual attributes such as identity, location, luminance, and orientation.
- Demonstrated how specialized neural pathways support complementary neural representations, efficient learning, and generalization.
- Produced multiple first-author peer-reviewed publications in computational neuroscience and neural computation.

Self-Supervised Learning for Computer Vision August 2022 – April 2023

Graduate Data Science Researcher, The Data Mine, Purdue University; Corporate Partner: Viasat

- Collaborated with corporate partner Viasat on self-supervised learning and computer vision research.
- Implemented self-supervised learning models in Python for visual representation learning.

Graph Neural Networks for Scientific Prediction August 2021 – April 2022

Graduate Data Science Researcher, The Data Mine, Purdue University; Corporate Partner: ATOM

- Collaborated with Accelerating Therapeutics for Opportunities in Medicine (ATOM) on machine learning approaches to opioid receptor pIC50 prediction.
- Implemented graph convolutional neural networks and random forest models in Python to predict molecular properties from scientific data.
- Developed experience applying machine learning to interdisciplinary scientific problems.

Neural Decoding of Word Spectrograms from Intracortical Recordings May 2018 – May 2019

Graduate Researcher, Brown University; Advisor: Dr. Wilson Truccolo

- Used long short-term memory (LSTM) models to decode word spectrograms from neural signals recorded via intracortical microelectrode arrays in auditory superior temporal cortex.
- Implemented phase retrieval algorithms to reconstruct acoustic signals from decoded spectrograms.
- Combined neural decoding and signal reconstruction methods to recover word-level acoustic information from neural recordings.

Bayesian Theory and Visual Perception of Size and Depth September 2016 – May 2017

Undergraduate Researcher, University of Minnesota; Advisor: Dr. Daniel Kersten

- Modeled visual perception of object size and depth as a Bayesian inference problem.

- Used Markov chain Monte Carlo (MCMC) sampling methods to approximate posterior distributions.
- Applied probabilistic modeling to study perceptual inference in human vision.

Characterizing Fluorescent Properties of mEos2 Proteins for Super-Resolution Microscopy
September 2015 – May 2017

Undergraduate Research Assistant, University of Minnesota; Advisor: Dr. Elias Puchner

- Characterized the fluorescent properties of mEos2 proteins in yeast cells for super-resolution microscopy.
- Experimentally determined the optimal excitation laser power for imaging mEos2 proteins.
- Optimized imaging conditions to improve signal-to-background ratio and obtain high-quality super-resolution images.

Technical Skills

Programming: Python, PyTorch, TensorFlow, R, MATLAB, C++, SQL
Machine Learning: Deep learning, convolutional neural networks, self-supervised learning, representation learning, model evaluation, reinforcement learning, transformers, natural language processing
Research Methods: Empirical machine learning (hypothesis-driven experimentation, ablation studies), computational modeling, Bayesian modeling, statistical inference, mixed-effects models
Neuroimaging: fMRI preprocessing, GLM analysis, single-trial beta estimation, multivariate pattern analysis, neural decoding

Ad Hoc Reviewer

Neural Networks, Scientific Reports, Vision Research, Trends in Cognitive Sciences

Teaching Experience

Project Teaching Assistant – Neuromatch Academy July 2026

Computational Neuroscience Summer Course 2026 (Synchronous Online)

– Guided and supported eight project groups of five to seven students in developing research questions, conducting literature reviews, writing Python code, and preparing abstracts and project presentations.

Limited-term Lecturer – PSY 39200CPAI Intro to Computational Psychology and AI - Purdue University

August 2025 - May 2026

– Designed a new upper-level undergraduate course in computational psychology and AI.
– Created tutorials with theories and programming exercises.
– Prepared lectures to introduce different topics to students.
– Guided student discussions and course projects.

Limited-term Lecturer – PSY 20100 Intro to Statistics in Psychology - Purdue University

August 2025 - May 2026

– Created tutorials with theories and calculation exercises.
– Prepared lectures to introduce different statistics topics to students.

Graduate Lecturer – PSY 32400 Intro to Cognitive Neuroscience (Asynchronous Online) - Purdue University

June 2025 - July 2025

– Prepared lectures to introduce the neurobiological foundations of cognition and the computational principles underlying them.

Graduate Lecturer – PSY 51300 Intro to Computational Cognitive Neuroscience - Purdue University

January 2025 - May 2025

- Redesigned and taught an upper-level course covering computational cognitive modeling, reinforcement learning, convolutional neural networks, transformers, natural language processing, large language models, active inference, and NeuroAI.
- Created tutorials with theories and programming exercises.
- Prepared lectures to introduce different topics to students.
- Guided student discussions and course projects.

Lead Teaching Assistant – Neuromatch Academy July 2021

Computational Neuroscience Summer Course 2021 (Synchronous Online)

- Guided small groups of students in all aspects of live online learning. This included guiding students in completion of code-based tutorials, guiding students in contextualizing the problem sets, and guiding students in developing peer-programming and self-learning skills.
- Guided students in their final project.
- Managed and provided support for 7-8 junior teaching assistants.

Teaching Assistant – Purdue University August 2019 - December 2024

- PSY 30500 Understanding and Analyzing Psychological Data (Fall 2024)
- PSY 20100 Introduction to Statistics in Psychology (Spring 2020, Fall 2021, Spring 2022, Fall 2022, Spring 2023, Fall 2023, Spring 2024)
- PSY 20000 Introduction to Cognitive Psychology (Fall 2019, Spring 2021)
- PSY 48400 The Psychology of Consciousness (Fall 2020)
- STAT 51400 Design of Experiments (Summer 2022)

Work Experience

Consultant for the Purdue Statistical Consulting Service (SCS) January 2024 - December 2024

- Experimental Design and Data Analysis Consulting: This service assists with all phases of research projects, including: proposal preparation, design of studies, survey design, data input strategies, data import/export, analysis of data, interpretation of results, presentation of results, other statistics or probability problems.
- Statistical Software Consulting: This service provides assistance with running a wide variety of statistical computing programs.

Service

Purdue Han Culture Association, Purdue University
Treasurer (May 2023 – Aug 2024); President (Aug 2024 – Oct 2024)

- Organized cultural events promoting Chinese culture (e.g., Mid-Autumn Festival, Lantern Festival, Chinese Culture Night Market, Master Chef competition)
- Managed budget and secured funding for events
- Facilitated community engagement and cross-cultural activities

Training / Workshops

Unlocking New Horizons in Cognitive Modeling with Simulation-Based Inference, Ohio State University

2026

Neuromatch Academy Summer Course in NeuroAI, Online 2024

Neuromatch Academy Summer Course in Deep Learning, Online 2021

Neuromatch Academy Summer Course in Computational Neuroscience, Online 2020

Berkeley Summer Course in Mining and Modeling Neuroscience Data, UC Berkeley 2018

Summer Visiting Undergraduate Student, UC Berkeley 2015

Awards

Postdoctoral Supplemental Travel Award, 2026

Compton Graduate Student Research Travel Award, 2024

Purdue Graduate Student Government (PGSG) First-Tier Travel Grant, 2024

Purdue Graduate Student Government (PGSG) Third-Tier Travel Grant, 2023

Yan Jici Physics Scholarship, Institute of Physics Chinese Academy of Sciences, 2014

First-Class Subject Scholarship, Sichuan University, 2014

Third-Class General Scholarship, Sichuan University, 2013

Outstanding Student, Sichuan University, 2013

References

Anne B. Sereno, Ph.D.
Professor
Department of Psychological Sciences and Weldon School of Biomedical Engineering
Purdue University
Email: asereno@purdue.edu

Sébastien Hélie, Ph.D.
Professor
Department of Psychological Sciences
Purdue University
Email: shelie@purdue.edu

Richard Schweickert, Ph.D.
Professor Emeritus
Department of Psychological Sciences
Purdue University
Email: schweick@purdue.edu